



LG Wing and LG Velvet

Powered by Snapdragon SoCs, the new swivel form-factor, dual-display phones have been launched. <http://dgit.in/nov20-49>



OnePlus Nord N10 and N100 launched

Price, specifications and availability for OnePlus' affordable lineup of phones revealed. <http://dgit.in/nov20-50>

Google Pixel 4a

Effortless and reliable

The fact that not much of the market got up and took note of the fact that Google wasn't bringing the Pixel 4 and 4 XL to India last year, save for us enthusiasts, speaks volumes about Google's hardware division's focus on the Indian market, and vice versa. But with India being one of the largest mobile markets, Google just can't give up that easy, can they? Hence, the Pixel 4a. Let's see how it fared in our review.

Design and display

The Pixel 4a is a hark back to the compact mid-rangers before the large screen mania gripped the market. And thanks to the ever shrinking bezels, the screen isn't very small. It's still a modest 5.8-inches. There's a 3.5mm headphone jack and a rear-mounted fingerprint sensor, that somehow refuses to acknowledge a sweaty finger, but otherwise is quite fast. The body is made of plastic with a matte finish.

We loved the one-handed usability, however, when watching movies and gaming, a large display provides a better overall experience.

The 5.8-inches packs pixels more densely, and the visuals are crisper and sharper than a larger FHD+ display. If you can live with the small footprint, watching movies isn't too bad. HDR is supported on Netflix and YouTube, and the battery drain is low enough to allow an episode or two while on the move.

Camera

The Pixel line has made its name for its magical camera. The Pixel 4a continues to use the Sony IMX363 12MP camera as the original Pixel released 4 years ago, and the results are quite at par with what you get on other smartphones in this price range. The shutter is fast in the day, but for a good Night Sight shot, you need a steady frame with nothing moving in it. The resulting images come out with

lots of details and sharpness and impressive dynamic range. However, this is also a camera you may get bored of easily if you are somewhat of a camera enthusiast. You have no control over the ISO, white balance or the shutter speed.

Moving on to low light, you get the regular Night Sight and the camera triggers the astrophotography mode when plunked on a tripod and pointed towards the night sky. From what we have seen from the Gcam app, the results are astoundingly good. Portraits are another strong point of the Pixel camera, and even after four years, Google is sticking to calculate depth of field using algorithms. While this allows for crisp details on the faces, the bokeh itself feels like a gaussian blur filter applied on Photoshop.

Performance

The Pixel 4a is not a flagship smartphone. Powered by the Snapdragon 730G and 6GB RAM, the Pixel 4a performs like the average mid-range smartphone on benchmarks. Using the Pixel 4a as a daily driver for more than a week, not once did it become sluggish and unresponsive. The software minimal and simple, and the app drawer is

surprisingly intuitive. Having said that, there's only so much you can improve with software. While the UI is responsive, heavier apps like Lightroom, Snapseed, and Google's own image processing takes a tad longer than we remember the older Pixel 3 taking. Games also take a bit of time to load. However, things like opening a Chrome tab, or switching over to YouTube happens in a fluid motion. We tried gaming and it wasn't a nice experience. We played a team deathmatch on Call of Duty: Mobile on a mobile network, and the performance was smooth enough with 60 FPS at 93% stability at high graphics and max frame rate. The display wasn't too washed out, but the size was too small for us, with less thumb space and aiming area.

Battery life

The 3140mAh battery on the Pixel 4a is endemic to that constraint. Don't expect this one to be a marathon runner like the Samsung Galaxy M51. The 18W fast charging feels outdated, and with over 2 hours needed to fully charge the battery, this could be a deal-breaker.

Bottomline

The Google Pixel 4a is perhaps the most polarising smartphone we tested this year. Only, with the lowered price tag, recommending it becomes easier. It makes the Android's fluidity more accessible to the masses. We'd say go for the experience this is able to provide. It's not unique anymore, but has the finesse only Google can offer.

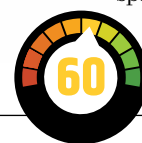
—Subhrojit Mallick

SPECIFICATIONS

DISPLAY: 5.8" FHD+ OLED | WEIGHT: 143g | BATTERY: 3140 mAh | MEMORY AND STORAGE: 6 GB RAM and 128 GB storage | PROCESSOR: Qualcomm Snapdragon 730G | REAR CAMERA: 12.2 MP dual-pixel with Auto-focus | FRONT CAMERA: 8 MP | VIDEO: Rear camera: 1080p @ 30 fps, 60 fps, 120 fps · 720p @ 30 fps, 60 fps, 240 fps | CHARGING: USB-C 18 W adaptor with 18 W fast charging | BLUETOOTH: v5.0 | OS: Android 10

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